

## Paper 2 Sections B & C — Practice Question Set

51 questions across four original passages

This booklet tests your ability to apply the Cat A (Locate-and-Paraphrase) and Cat B (Inference) techniques from the Working Notes (the companion document). Use the three mnemonics — **SWIFT** to identify the category, **FLIP** to execute a Cat A answer, and **EIL** to execute a Cat B answer — before reaching for the sentence template for each question type.

Each question is tagged with its question-type code (A1–A8 for Locate-and-Paraphrase, B1–B8 for Inference). Mark allocation is given in square brackets at the end of every question, exactly as in the real exam.

A separate Answer Key document provides model answers with full annotated reasoning for every question.

**Exam discipline.** Total: 100 marks. Suggested timing: 1 hour 40 minutes for the questions, 10 minutes to read all four passages once. Pay attention to mark allocation (one mark per distinct point) and answer-line allocation (a guide to length).

### Passage 1 — “The Last Crossing” (narrative)

**Passage 1 — Narrative**

**1** The lights went out just as Ravi reached the bus stop. One moment the orange glow of the streetlamps lined Bukit Timah Road like a row of obedient soldiers; the next, the whole stretch was swallowed by the dark. He stopped walking. The silence that followed felt strange — as though the night itself had been holding its breath, waiting for the city to fall.

**2** He should have been home an hour ago. His mother’s last message — *come home now, please* — had arrived at half past ten, and he had not replied. The battery icon on his phone now blinked a feeble red. He pressed the screen against his palm, hoping the warmth might coax a few more minutes of life from it. It refused, blinking back with the indifference of something already dead.

**3** Across the road, the bus stop sat marooned in the gloom, its shelter no longer a shelter but a black mouth opening into nothing. There were no buses — there had not been one for twenty minutes — and the few cars that passed did so cautiously, their headlights sweeping over Ravi’s face like searchlights in a prison yard. He felt suddenly visible and suddenly alone, and could not say which was worse.

**4** “Bus not coming, boy,” said a voice behind him. An old man, white-haired, leaning on a cane, was peering at him from beneath the awning of a shuttered shop. “Blackout. Whole island, I heard. You walking home or what?”

**5** Ravi had not thought of walking. His house was four kilometres away — a distance that, in daylight and with full battery, would have seemed trivial. Now, in the moonless dark, it stretched ahead of him like a hostile country. He looked at the old man. He looked at the dead phone. He thought of his mother, who would by now be sitting at the kitchen table watching the clock, and his stomach tightened.

**6** “I’ll walk,” he said.

**7** The old man nodded slowly. “Then walk fast. The dark plays tricks — it shrinks the brave and emboldens the cowardly. Don’t let it work on you.”

**8** Ravi set off. The first hundred metres were the worst. Every shadow seemed to lean towards him; every rustle in the bushes was a wild dog or a thief or worse. His own footsteps sounded too loud, as if the road itself was reporting his progress to whoever might be listening. But after a while, his eyes began to adjust, and the dark became less a wall than a curtain — thick, but passable.

**9** He thought of his mother. He thought of how, when he had been small, he had been afraid of the corridor between his bedroom and the bathroom, and how she had walked it with him every night, holding his hand, until he could walk it alone. He had not held her hand in years.

**10** By the time he reached his block, the lights had come back on. The whole estate was lit as if nothing had happened. His mother was waiting at the door, her face tight with worry, and when she saw him she did not speak — she only pulled him into a fierce embrace and held him as if she had been the one walking through the dark.

**Questions 1–16** refer to Passage 1.

- 1.** In Paragraph 1, why do you think Ravi stops walking when the lights go out? Give one detail from the paragraph to support your answer. [TYPE B1] [2]
- 2.** The writer describes the streetlamps in Paragraph 1 as ‘a row of obedient soldiers’. What does this simile suggest about the streetlamps before the blackout? [TYPE B5] [1]
- 3.** In Paragraph 2, identify **one** word that suggests Ravi’s phone was almost out of power. [TYPE A2] [1]
- 4.** In Paragraph 2, the writer says the phone blinked back ‘with the indifference of something already dead’. What does this personification suggest about the phone? [TYPE B5] [2]
- 5.** In Paragraph 3, the writer compares the bus stop to ‘a black mouth opening into nothing’. Explain how the language used in Paragraph 3 makes the bus stop appear threatening. Support your answer with **two** details. [TYPE B6] [2]
- 6.** In Paragraph 3, the headlights ‘swept over Ravi’s face like searchlights in a prison yard’. What does this simile suggest about how Ravi feels at this moment? [TYPE B5] [1]
- 7.** From Paragraph 4, give **one** detail that suggests the old man has been observing Ravi before he speaks. [TYPE A1] [1]

8. In Paragraph 5, Ravi describes the four-kilometre walk home as stretching ahead ‘like a hostile country’. Using your **own words**, explain what this comparison tells us about Ravi’s state of mind. [TYPE B4] [2]
9. In Paragraph 7, the old man advises Ravi: ‘the dark plays tricks — it shrinks the brave and emboldens the cowardly’. What is the tone of the old man’s comment? [TYPE B3] [1]
10. In Paragraph 8, the writer says Ravi’s footsteps sounded ‘as if the road itself was reporting his progress to whoever might be listening’. Explain how this phrase suggests that Ravi feels vulnerable. [TYPE B7] [1]
11. In Paragraph 8, the writer says the dark became ‘less a wall than a curtain’. Identify the **contrast** that the writer is drawing here. [TYPE A6] [1]
12. From Paragraph 9, give **two** pieces of evidence that suggest Ravi’s relationship with his mother has changed since his childhood. [TYPE A4] [2]
13. In Paragraph 10, when Ravi’s mother sees him, she ‘did not speak — she only pulled him into a fierce embrace’. What does this behaviour suggest about her feelings? [TYPE B1] [2]
14. The writer says that Ravi’s mother held him ‘as if she had been the one walking through the dark’. What does this final image tell us about the mother? [TYPE B2] [1]
15. **Flow chart.** The structure of the passage reflects Ravi’s emotional state at different stages of the night. Complete the flow chart by choosing **one phrase** from the box for each stage. There are extra phrases you do not need. [TYPE A7] [4]

**Phrase bank:** feeling suddenly exposed and isolated • refusing to confront a danger • resolving to act despite fear • gradually overcoming his fear • reflecting on the unspoken bond with a parent • enjoying the freedom of solitude • realising he is no longer needed at home

- Paragraphs 1–3: .....
- Paragraphs 4–6: .....
- Paragraphs 7–8: .....
- Paragraphs 9–10: .....

16. From the whole passage, what **impression** do you get of Ravi as a character? [TYPE B2] [2]

Passage 2 — “The Last Stall” (narrative)

### Passage 2 — Narrative

**1** Madam Lim had been frying carrot cake at the same hawker stall for forty-three years. Her arms, lean and corded, moved with the certainty of habit: a wrist-flick of dark soy here, a scatter of preserved radish there, the chai poh hissing as it met the hot oil. She did not look at her hands as she worked. She did not need to.

**2** The letter from the town council had come on a Tuesday. *Block 213 to undergo redevelopment. All existing tenancies will not be renewed beyond December.* She had read it twice, folded it carefully, and placed it under the cash tin. Then she had gone back to the wok. There were still customers to serve. There were always customers to serve.

**3** The regulars knew. Mr Goh, who had eaten her black carrot cake every Saturday since 1991, had pressed his hand against the glass partition that morning and shaken his head slowly. “Where ah, Madam Lim? After December, where?” She had smiled at him — a quick, tired smile — and told him not to think about it. He had eaten his plate in silence and tipped her ten dollars for a five-dollar meal.

**4** Her son had been telling her for years to retire. He was a project manager now, earning enough to support her without difficulty. “Ma, you don’t have to work anymore.” But he did not understand. The stall was not work. The stall was the shape her days had taken — the early-morning rinse of the wok, the careful slicing of the radish cake, the steady arrival of the regulars between seven and eleven. Remove the stall and there would be nothing for the day to be poured into.

**5** Some evenings, after the last customer had left, she would stand at the front of the stall and look down the corridor of the hawker centre. The other stalls were closing too: the prawn-noodle man, the laksa lady, the young couple who had taken over the cze char unit only three years ago. They would all leave. The redevelopment would replace the hawker centre with a coffee chain and a convenience store. She had been told it would be ‘progress’.

**6** She did not feel angry. Anger was for younger women. What she felt was something quieter — a slow, settling sadness, like the sediment at the bottom of a glass of kopi-o left too long. She would serve her last plate of carrot cake in December. She would scrub the wok, turn off the gas, and lock the metal shutter for the last time. And then, she supposed, the days would begin to take some other shape, and she would have to learn what that shape was.

Questions 17–29 refer to Passage 2.

**17.** From Paragraph 1, identify **one** detail that suggests Madam Lim is highly experienced at her work. [TYPE A1] [1]

**18.** In Paragraph 1, the writer says Madam Lim’s arms moved ‘with the certainty of habit’. Using your **own words**, explain what this phrase tells us about how she works. [TYPE A3] [2]

**19.** In Paragraph 2, after reading the letter from the town council, Madam Lim ‘folded it carefully, and placed it under the cash tin’. What does this behaviour suggest about her reaction to the news? [TYPE B1] [2]

**20.** In Paragraph 2, the writer repeats the sentence: ‘There were still customers to serve. There were always customers to serve.’ What is the effect of this repetition? [TYPE B6] [2]

**21.** In Paragraph 3, Mr Goh tipped Madam Lim ‘ten dollars for a five-dollar meal’. What does this gesture suggest about Mr Goh’s feelings? [TYPE B1] [1]

**22.** From Paragraph 3, give **one** piece of evidence that shows Madam Lim was trying to hide her own feelings from Mr Goh. [TYPE A1] [1]

**23.** Explain in your **own words** why Madam Lim does not want to retire, even though her son can support her financially. Refer to Paragraph 4. [TYPE A3] [2]

**24.** In Paragraph 4, the writer says: ‘Remove the stall and there would be nothing for the day to be poured into.’ What does this metaphor suggest about Madam Lim’s relationship with her stall? [TYPE B5] [2]

**25.** From Paragraph 5, identify **two** other hawker stalls that will also be closing. [TYPE A1] [1]

**26.** In Paragraph 6, the writer says that Madam Lim feels ‘a slow, settling sadness, like the sediment at the bottom of a glass of kopi-o left too long’. What does this simile suggest about the **nature** of her

sadness? [TYPE B5] [2]

27. What is the writer's **tone** when describing Madam Lim in Paragraph 6? [TYPE B3] [1]

28. What **impression** do you get of Madam Lim's character from the whole passage? [TYPE B2] [2]

29. Identify the phrase in Paragraph 6, of **not more than five words**, that captures how Madam Lim feels about her loss. [TYPE A2] [1]

### Passage 3 — "The Quiet Death of Singapore's Reading Culture" (non-narrative)

#### Passage 3 — Non-narrative article

**1** For a country that prides itself on educational excellence, Singapore reads remarkably little. The latest National Library Board statistics show that the average Singaporean adult reads only two books per year for leisure — a figure that has more than halved over the past decade. We are, by any reasonable measure, a nation that has forgotten how to read.

**2** The reasons are not mysterious. The smartphone has colonised the spaces where reading once lived: the bus commute, the queue at the food court, the half-hour before bed. Where a paperback once filled these moments, a glowing rectangle now does. The phone is more convenient, more responsive, and infinitely more varied — but it does not, for the most part, ask its user to think. It asks only that its user keep scrolling.

**3** Schools, too, must take some of the blame. Reading is no longer presented as a pleasure but as a chore — a thing to be done for the comprehension test, the literature paper, the project work. Books in classrooms are dissected rather than enjoyed, broken apart for 'themes' and 'devices' until the original delight has been thoroughly drained out. By the time most students leave secondary school, they have learned to associate reading with effort rather than with rest. They put the books down. They do not pick them up again.

**4** The cost of this collective forgetting is not obvious, but it is real. Reading cultivates a kind of attention that no other activity replicates — a long, slow, deepening attention. To read a novel is to inhabit another consciousness for two hundred pages; to read an essay is to follow an argument through its full development. These are not small skills. They are the foundations of empathy, of judgement, of independent thought. A society that does not read will, in time, become a society that does not think.

**5** Some will object that reading has not died; it has merely changed. We read more text now than at any time in human history, they will argue — emails, articles, captions, comments. But this misses the point. The kind of reading that builds the mind is not the skimming, scanning kind. It is the long-form, sustained reading that almost nobody does anymore. Saying that scrolling Instagram counts as reading is like saying that snacking on biscuits counts as having dinner.

**6** What is to be done? Libraries can hold all the reading-promotion campaigns they wish; the government can pour all the money it wishes into book vouchers. None of it will work unless we, as parents and teachers and citizens, model the behaviour we want to see. Children do not read because they are told to. They read because they see the adults around them reading. The cure for the death of reading is, in the end, embarrassingly simple: pick up a book. Sit down. Begin.

Questions 30–44 refer to Passage 3.

30. In Paragraph 1, why does the writer describe Singapore as a country that has 'forgotten how to read'? Refer to the paragraph for your answer. [TYPE A8] [1]

31. In Paragraph 2, the writer says the smartphone has 'colonised the spaces where reading once lived'. What does the word 'colonised' suggest about the smartphone's role? [TYPE B7] [2]

32. From Paragraph 2, give **one** reason why the writer believes the smartphone has displaced reading. [TYPE A8] [1]

33. In Paragraph 3, why does the writer blame schools for the decline in reading? Give **two** reasons in your own words. [TYPE A3] [2]

34. In Paragraph 3, the writer puts the words 'themes' and 'devices' in inverted commas. Why does the writer choose to do this? [TYPE B8] [2]

35. In Paragraph 4, the writer claims that the cost of the decline in reading is ‘real’. Give **three** pieces of evidence from Paragraph 4 that support this claim. [TYPE A4] [3]
36. In Paragraph 4, the writer concludes that ‘a society that does not read will, in time, become a society that does not think’. What is the writer’s **tone** when he makes this statement? [TYPE B3] [1]
37. In Paragraph 5, the writer compares scrolling Instagram with reading to ‘snacking on biscuits’ compared with ‘having dinner’. What does this comparison suggest about the difference between the two kinds of reading? [TYPE B5] [2]
38. From Paragraph 5, identify the contrast the writer draws between two kinds of reading. [TYPE A6] [2]
39. In Paragraph 6, why does the writer say that reading-promotion campaigns and book vouchers ‘will not work’? Give the reason in your own words. [TYPE A8] [2]
40. In Paragraph 6, the writer ends with the instruction: ‘pick up a book. Sit down. Begin.’ What is the effect of this short, three-sentence ending? [TYPE B6] [2]
41. Here is part of a conversation between two students, Aisha and Devan, who have read this article. [TYPE A5] [3]

**Aisha:** “The decline in reading is mostly the fault of technology.”

**Devan:** “No — it’s the way reading is taught in schools that has killed it.”

- (a) Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 2 that supports Aisha’s view. [1]
- (b) Give **two** pieces of evidence from Paragraph 3 that support Devan’s view. [2]
42. From Paragraph 1, what is the writer’s **attitude** towards the Singaporean reading public? [TYPE B3] [1]
43. In Paragraph 4, the writer says reading is ‘the foundation of empathy, of judgement, of independent thought.’ Why does the writer choose to refer to these three specific qualities? [TYPE A8] [2]
44. From the whole passage, give **two** different reasons the writer offers for the decline of reading in Singapore. [TYPE A1] [2]

Passage 4 — “Why We Sleep Less Than Our Grandparents Did” (non-narrative)

### Passage 4 — Non-narrative article

**1** In 1960, the average adult in the developed world slept just over eight hours a night. Today, that figure has fallen to under six and a half. In the space of three generations, we have shaved more than a fifth of our sleep — not by choice, exactly, but not entirely against our will either. We have built a world in which sleep is the enemy of productivity, and we have largely accepted that bargain.

**2** The causes of this collapse are several. The most obvious is artificial light. The incandescent bulb gave the nineteenth century its first taste of after-dark productivity; the LED screen has given the twenty-first an unbroken floodlit existence. The brain, which evolved to read darkness as a signal for sleep, no longer receives that signal. It receives, instead, the soft blue glow of the laptop and the phone — a glow that mimics, almost exactly, the wavelength of midday sunlight. Small wonder that we find it hard to sleep when our brains are being told it is still noon.

**3** The second cause is cultural. Where our grandparents thought of sleep as a basic human need — closer to food and water than to leisure — we have learned to think of it as a luxury, even a self-indulgence. A friend who sleeps nine hours a night is regarded with mild suspicion, as though he is getting away with something. The man who boasts that he ‘only needs four’ is admired, even envied. The bragging right is no longer how much you sleep but how little.

**4** The consequences are alarming. Chronic sleep deprivation has been linked, in major studies, to obesity, diabetes, heart disease, depression, and dementia. The Centers for Disease Control in the United States has called insufficient sleep a ‘public health epidemic’. And yet the cultural pressure to sleep less, to work later, to be ‘productive’ at every hour, shows no sign of weakening. We continue to treat sleep as the negotiable item in our schedules — the thing we cut when something else needs more time.

**5** What we have failed to grasp is that sleep is not the absence of activity; it is one of the most demanding biological processes the body undertakes. It is during sleep that memories are consolidated, that toxins are cleared from the brain, that the immune system rebuilds itself. To skimp on sleep is not to gain extra hours of life — it is to mortgage them. The bill, eventually, comes due.

**Questions 45–51** refer to Passage 4.

**45.** From Paragraph 1, give the writer’s specific figure for the **reduction** in average sleep over the past three generations. [TYPE A1] [1]

**46.** In Paragraph 1, the writer says that we have ‘built a world in which sleep is the enemy of productivity’. What does this phrase suggest about modern attitudes to sleep? [TYPE B7] [2]

**47.** In Paragraph 2, why is the blue light from screens particularly disruptive to sleep? Give the reason in your **own words**. [TYPE A8] [2]

**48.** In Paragraph 3, identify the **contrast** between how our grandparents and our generation regard sleep. [TYPE A6] [2]

**49.** In Paragraph 3, the writer puts the word ‘productive’ in inverted commas (also in Paragraph 4). Why does the writer choose to do this? [TYPE B8] [2]

**50.** In Paragraph 5, the writer uses the metaphor: ‘to skimp on sleep is not to gain extra hours of life — it is to mortgage them. The bill, eventually, comes due.’ What does this metaphor suggest about the long-term effect of sleep deprivation? [TYPE B5] [2]

**51.** In Paragraph 4, the writer calls insufficient sleep a ‘public health epidemic’. Why does the writer choose to use this strong phrase? [TYPE A8] [2]

### End of Question Booklet

**Total: 100 marks.** Once you have attempted all 51 questions, consult the companion Answer Key document for model answers, annotated reasoning, and marker commentary.